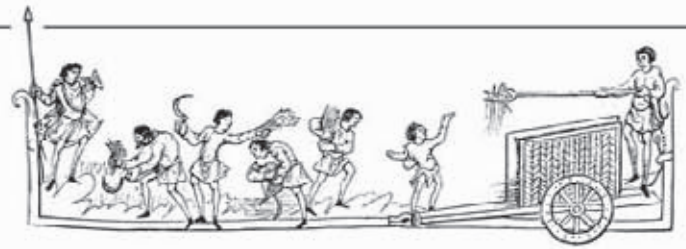


The story of wheat

WHEAT HAS BEEN CULTIVATED by humans as a valuable source of food for at least 9,000 years. Grains of wheat have been found preserved in ancient Egyptian tombs, and it is known that it was the chief cereal of the ancient Greeks and Romans. The cultivation of wheat originated in the region known as the Fertile Crescent, which includes

part of modern-day Israel, Turkey, Iraq, and Iran. Once a rich farming area, today much of it is desert. Wheat is now grown in most parts of the world, and the quality has improved greatly. The early, primitive species, such as einkorn and emmer, had long, thin stalks that were easily broken in bad weather. Their small grains meant that a large number of plants only produced a relatively low yield of grain. Today, as a result of extensive breeding programs, better varieties have been found that have higher yields, resist drought, and withstand disease.



FOOD FOR THE MASSES

People have grown cereals for food for thousands of years, as this picture from the 11th century shows.



CUTTING THE CORN

Wild grasses drop their ripe seeds. The first farmers selected plants that held on to the seeds, so that the grain could be harvested.

Grains of wild einkorn

WILD EINKORN

This wild grass is probably one of the ancestors of all cultivated wheats. It has long, thin stalks and small heads and grains.

EINKORN

This early wheat species is still grown in parts of Turkey for animal feed. Its small grains are difficult to thresh.

WILD EMMER

This wild grass is the ancestor of emmer, another primitive wheat. The heads and grains are larger than those of einkorn.

EMMER

Emmer was the chief cereal in ancient Greek and Roman times. It is one of the ancestors of modern cultivated wheat varieties.

Grains of emmer